Identity 2.0:

Identity Formation in the Digital Realm

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Introduction

Exploring who you really are in the real world isn't an easy task. It's like trying to solve a complex puzzle with many pieces that keep changing. One important step in this process of developing a sense of identity is being able to explore, trying out different selves to see what fits you before you commit. However, many factors such as expectations set by one's culture and by your social context, fear of rejection, peer pressure from friends and family can make this rather hard. Add on top of this that identity is something always in flux, and that changing parts about yourself is hard, and many people land in a phase where they commit pre-maturely to an identity, a phenomenon referred to as identity foreclosure by James Marcia (Lumen 2023).

However, what if there was a place where all of these hurdles did not exist, where one can change and explore their identity at will, and infinite social contexts without consequences to try out different selves. I will argue in this paper about how online digital spaces are on their way to being able to provide such an experience, and why this is valuable.

Digital spaces have been a thing for a very long time, they refer to any space that exists online. For example, when browsing the internet, users are moving through different digital spaces. Each website is like a room with information, pictures, and links to other rooms. It's like walking through a big building with lots of doors leading to different places. Although for this paper, I specifically want to zoom in on online spaces where users can interact with each other. These spaces can be anything from simple websites to complex virtual worlds. Think of video games or social media platforms. In a video game, users actively play and explore. They can also have social elements, allowing users to interact with others.

Something a lot of these spaces have in common is the use of avatars. Avatars are the characters or symbols we use to represent ourselves in online worlds. They act as digital representations of users, representing them in the digital space they belong too. Users can customize these avatars, from mirroring themselves to something completely different. Other than providing users with a way to represent themselves, avatars also let users immerse themselves in the digital space. Avatars can come in all kinds of forms, from simple images or profile pages on social media, to controllable and customizable characters in video games.

Avatars also impact interaction between users of digital spaces. As Manninen and Kujanpää state, the main difference between virtual worlds and the physical world is the need for an avatar as a proxy for the player and all his/her possible communication conducted in the virtual environment (Manninen 2007). Just like in real life, the looks of the avatar, body language, pre-existing opinions about elements of the avatar and way more affect how users interact with each other.

When users are in control of how they are perceived, this opens up a playground of identity, and this is my main point of interest. I believe that these digital spaces may be a front runner of how we might look at concepts like identity and gender in the future, and that they can help individuals with the process of identity formation where real life fails to provide. While I think even self-presentation on social media platforms like Facebook and Discord poses an interesting debate, I will specifically talk about VRChat (VRChat Inc. 2017) and other games where avatars are highly customizable and vital to the digital space, like MMORPGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Role Playing Games). This is because immersion and connection to the virtual world and avatar plays an important role.

Thesis Statement

What I want to argue in this paper, is that digital social spaces that use avatars facilitate identity formation, because they enable identity experimentation, reduce social risk, and allow individuals to experience ideal or alternative selves through embodied representation.

I will do this by first giving context and introducing the online spaces in question. Then I will argue that first of all, these spaces provide a great environment for individuals to play and explore with identity, and finally I will argue why this is valuable and how it can help individuals.

Digital spaces and their avatars

So where do these digital spaces and their avatars exactly come from? The concept of a digital space traces back to the early 1980s, when online communication primarily relied on text-based platforms. Back then, these spaces were nothing more than simple text-based

forums and messaging websites where users could interact with each other. The term "avatar" was popularized by Neal Stephenson's novel "Snow Crash " (Stephenson 1992), where it referred to digital characters in a virtual reality metaverse. With the introduction of graphical imagery, users could create personalized avatars with basic customization options. These avatars mostly used to allow users to navigate and communicate on forums and other sites, and were often limited to static images or simple animations.

However, as internet speeds increased and graphics technology advanced, digital spaces and their avatars gained more detailed appearances, animations and features, making online interactions feel more lifelike. Digital spaces would expand to include activities that users can do together, and more ways to express themselves. Social media websites like Facebook allowed users to select profile pictures, while gaming platforms like Xbox Live and PlayStation Network introduced customizable gamer avatars and made it possible to make friends while playing games. Virtual worlds like Second Life (Linden Lab 2003) allowed users to create and customize their avatars' appearances, clothing, and accessories, further increasing the users ability to be in control of their self-presentation. This remained, and as time went on, avatars in digital spaces kept evolving. Users could create avatars with more and more intricate details, reflecting their real-world appearance or imaginative personas.

A popular subgenre of digital spaces that flourished around this time were games, more specifically MMORPGs, which are often considered among the most immersive games. They feature massive virtual worlds that users can interact with through their character, an avatar. An MMORPG character commonly features customizable gender, race, many body features, attire, accessoires and more. MMORPG worlds usually feature up to hundreds of players working together, battling each other, trading goods and many more activities, all of which users experience through the virtual interface of their avatar. Players would band together, making player groups called guilds and rely on each other. It is safe to say that these games were among the first to offer a fully digital world, an escape from real life. “For many MMORPG players, it is this idea of a digital world separated from real life where they can be another person, where they can achieve feats, meet others and escape that makes them invest time in the games.” (Yee 2005).

The latest and most immersive incarnations of digital spaces are those that reside in Virtual Reality (VR). With the rise of head-mounted displays (HDM), virtual social environments

started becoming popular. They are digital spaces that allow people to interact, socialize, and engage with one another in a manner that simulates real-world social experiences, and create a sense of presence and shared interaction, even when participants are physically located in different parts of the world. Virtual social environments can range from simple chat rooms and social spaces, to online conferences and games. These social environments also feature avatars, akin to MMORPGs they are usually virtual characters that users are allowed to customize and control. However, when using such a HDM, users are transported to the virtual environment as opposed to looking at a computer screen. When they look down, they do not see their own feet and body, they see their avatar. This ups the immersion levels and bond between a user and their avatar by that much. Users may struggle separating what is actually their body and their avatar, a term that is called body illusion in existing research (Slater 2014), and has been around for way longer than VR has (for example how they use mirroring body parts to deal with phantom pain after an amputation).

While many of the points I will make later are extendable to many digital spaces and their avatars, immersion and connection to the avatar play a huge role in how strongly they apply. This immersion is obviously the highest in virtual reality, hence they are my point of interest. The most famous instance of such a social, online digital space is VRChat (VRChat Inc. 2017), a virtual reality application officially released back in 2017. At its core, VRChat is a virtual reality based social platform where users can interact through their avatars. Users can upload any three dimensional model to use as their avatar. Multiple options to support full body tracking, facial expressions and more exist to allow for max immersion. In the platform, users can create customizable worlds which act like hubs for people to interact with each other. Users can participate in various activities, like playing games together, watching movies, and visiting digital cities. There are even concert and dance clubs in VRChat featuring real artists. I will be referencing VRChat many more times in this paper, as today, it is arguably the number one provider of an immersive, digitally social experience.

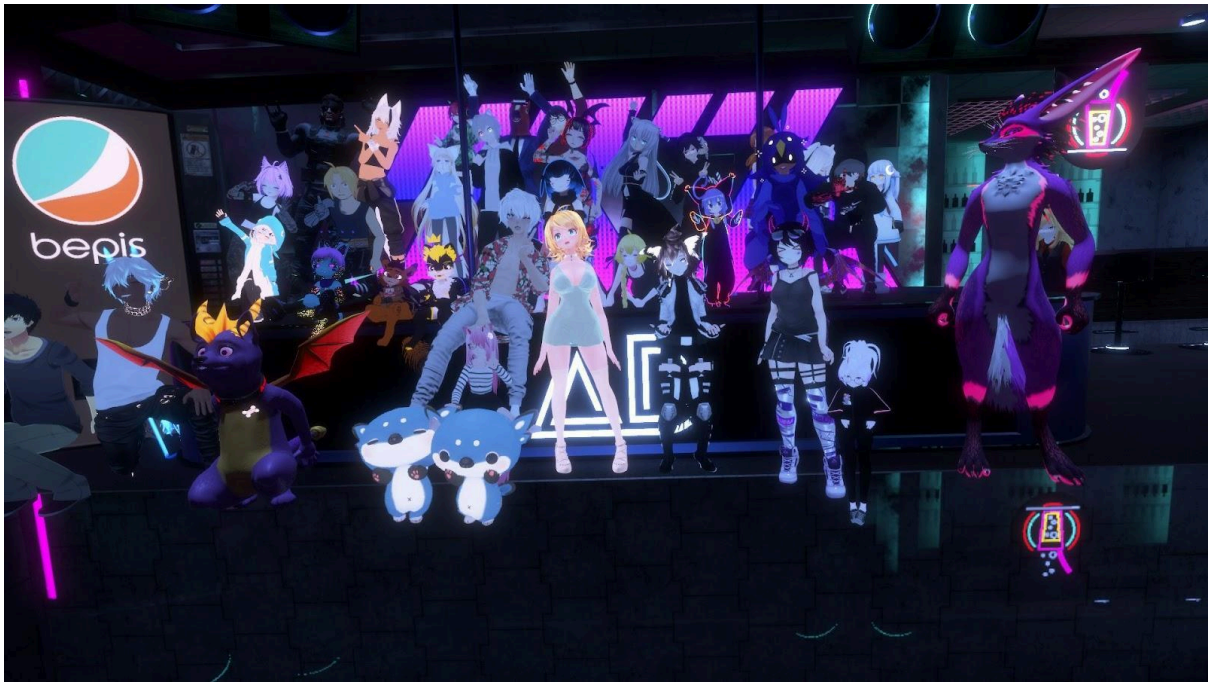
Avatars as other selves

A common idea found in the landscape of identity exploration is the notion of "other selves", which refers to the several facets of a person's personality that emerge under certain conditions or within particular contexts. According to this idea, a person is not limited to a single, unchanging identity but rather has a variety of selves that manifest depending on external factors and circumstances. It has existed since long, with philosophers like William James and Henri Bergson have also thought about the idea of alternate selves. James poses the idea to divide the “empirical self”, which loosely means that what we like to think of as “me” into different selves already back in 1890. “Properly speaking, a man has as many social selves as there are individuals who recognize him and carry an image of him in their mind. But as the individuals who carry the images fall naturally into classes, we may practically say that he has as many different social selves as there are distinct groups of persons about whose opinion he cares. He generally shows a different side of himself to each of these different groups. Many a youth who is demure enough before his parents and teachers, swears and swaggers like a pirate among his 'tough' young friends.” (James 1980)

The use of other selves derives from their need to accommodate dimensions of identity that might be hindered or unexpressed within the cultural or social context that an individual may find themselves in. It is rather easy to draw the parallel to avatars and digital spaces here, as they provide social contexts that can be disconnected from society, where the user can express their other selves with reduced risk. These online social environments each come with their own set of rules. groups and expectations, and creating an avatar there is much akin to adapting your behavior to a social group in real life. Individuals can use avatars as a medium to perform other selves.

Users of these digital spaces also tend to connect with their avatar in meaningful ways. The aforementioned customization options and the sense of ownership over the avatar that they provide help with this; avatars are a personal creation. Avatars in many digital spaces offer their users more ways of self presentation and expression than real life. These virtual representations are not limited by real life. MMORPGs usually offer players the ability to perform as an entirely different race, sex and gender. Social VR games go a step further, allowing users to fully customize their models, where fantasy is the users limit. This offers users the ability to express themselves, to sculpt their other selves in new ways. Users can

dress up their avatars without financial restrictions, choose to perform as a completely different self or create something that resembles the person behind the avatar. Avatars are also more than just a graphical presentation. In games, players actions, achievements and more are tied to their avatar.



VR users and their avatars taking a group picture in VRChat (RizumuVR 2020)

It is not only avatars that offer users the ability to enact other selves in digital spaces. Many of these spaces provide a context similar enough to real life that allows users to actually experience the other self as well. Multiplayer games and social platforms will have an avatar be the medium that users interact through with their peers. Other users will perceive them as their avatar, they will approach others without a clue of what the actual person behind the avatar is like, since they can only see their avatar. Their expectations and prejudices are based on the avatar. This is a stark difference in social interaction in real life. In these digital spaces, the user is, within the limitations of the digital space, fully in control of how they self-present, which makes it easier to perform parts of themselves. The most modern incarnation of avatars, VR avatars offer users social experiences mimicking the real version pretty closely, and although some social cues are missing, like how most VR systems do not support detection of cues like blinds, facial expressions and gazes that can have an impact on personal understanding, users appear to efficiently compensate for

these missing social and behavioral cues by shifting their attentions to other behavioral channels. (Roth 2016)

These building blocks are what allow users to have immersive and semi-realistic social experiences online with a low accessibility barrier, and what pave the way to exploring identity through avatars. Users can shape their avatar and personality online however they see it, without many consequences due to the disconnected nature of these spaces. This leads to users exploring the other selves online that they cannot in real life. This phenomenon is covered by studies as well. A study by done by Cacioli and Mussap found that players of MMORPGs tend to shape their avatar according to their ideal self (which is an other self that embodies an, what the individual considers, idealized version of themselves), "While users apparently grow more attached to their avatar if its body differs significantly (in an idealized way) from theirs, it looks as if great differences in personality between the two actually reduces satisfaction. In other words, trying to behave in a very different way from one's offline self in VWs [virtual worlds] is not particularly satisfying" (Cacioli 2014). As time goes on, digital spaces will increasingly offer more and more of these tools to help users shape their online personas and explore their other selves.

Digital spaces as identity playgrounds

We already established how digital spaces offer the tools for users to express other selves in the space. They provide a wide range of customization options available which allow users to self-express themselves and be in control of their self-presentation, and tweak their avatar to whatever other self they feel like in that digital space. Furthermore they provide a social environment where the avatar is the interface of interaction. I would like to now argue that specifically these digital spaces not only offer the opportunity, but are actually a prime environment for exploring your other selves. I believe digital spaces in general facilitate it for individuals to express sides of themselves that they usually suppress.

Aside from allowing users to self-express themselves, another major benefit of avatars is the ease of change. Users can switch up their other self just by making a new avatar, which opens up a whole new alley of identity experimentation. Male users can experience social interaction through a female avatar, but if they do not like it they can quickly change back, or try something else. Users can change how others perceive them with just the click of the

button. Changing how someone is perceived with the press of a (few) button(s) is an important key to opening up the identity playground.

It is also not just easy to alter your avatar, but digital spaces provide infinite social contexts that are easy to access. In the real world, the other selves William James labels as social selves are inherently tied to social groups. Changing social groups is not easy, as people remember your face and behavior, hence it can be hard to find a social group for individuals to express themselves in. There is also the social context they live in. A very interesting example that we will get later deeper into is that VR chat has a large transgender community, and a story often heard is that VR chat allows these users to experience the other gender while the cultural expectations of where they live would normally make this very difficult. In fact, while avatars certainly intensify and facilitate expressing another self, it can even be done without, just by the fact that digital spaces provide these social contexts and animosity. Users can experiment by doing something as simple as joining a random voice chat, even though the voice will act as the limiter on how much they can change up their identity. Compared to finding a new social group in real life, digital spaces are an extremely accessible alternative. They will always be up and running, and users are always a few clicks away from being able to interact with new people, from the comfort of their own room.

Societal expectations aside, these spaces are also mostly anonymous. When changing yourself in real life, people will often comment, question you and ask you to justify your changes, which can make trying a change seem like a hassle. Through an avatar, no one knows the real you, and it is this disconnection of the real world that makes it easier to show a side of yourself that you have not. Experimenting in digital spaces carries a lower risk and commitment compared to its real world counterpart. For example, exploring your own gender in the real world is hard, especially for those that live in social contexts where gender exploration is still treated harshly. Gender exploration often includes wearing different clothes, changing how you act, your hair and your lifestyle. These are generally visible things, and your environment might react to that. Compare this to for example VRChat, where with the click of (a few) buttons, users can fully experience being perceived as whatever they want in a safe, experimental environment. It is one of those rare risk free spaces where individuals can explore their gender without consequences.

You can be whoever you want to be. You can completely redefine yourself if you want. You can be the opposite sex. You can be more talkative. You can be less talkative. Whatever. You can just be whoever you want really, whoever you have the capacity to be. You don't have to worry about the slots other people put you in as much. It's easier to change the way people perceive you, because all they' ve got is what you show them. They don't look at your body and make assumptions. They don't hear your accent and make assumptions. All they see is your words.
(Grodin 1996, p158)

Contributing to identity formation

I just argued that digital spaces can provide a safe and easy to access space to perform other selves, but one might ask themselves why is this so valuable. I would like to argue this through the theory of self concept. Carl Rogers' self-concept theory highlights that self-concept is the collection of beliefs and feelings we have about ourselves. It forms through interactions and experiences and affects our well-being. Rogers emphasized the significance of unconditional acceptance and congruence (alignment between self-concept and experiences) for personal growth and mental health. It is also impacted by your body. Two important terms Rogers introduced are congruence and its counterpart incongruence. Congruence is the degree of how much your self-image lines up with your ideal self, with incongruence being the opposite. When there is a large gap between how you currently see yourself, and your ideal self, you are said to be incongruent, and this can lower your self esteem, because you see yourself far from the person you want to be (Cherry 2022). My first main argument is that these digital spaces can help an individual connect with their ideal self, therefore becoming more congruent.

A very common example that can be labeled as incongruence is dysphoria within transgender people, which is a distressing and discomforting emotional state stemming from a misalignment between an individual's gender identity and the sex assigned to them at birth, in other words, they feel incongruent because their ideal self has a different gender or sex. Dysphoria can manifest in various ways. Body dysphoria involves a deep sense of unease or dissatisfaction with their physical attributes that do not align with their gender identity, like a trans woman having a deep voice. Social dysphoria occurs when trans people are misgendered or when others use names or pronouns that do not align with their gender identity. Moreover, the fear of discrimination, stigmatization, or violence

due to their transgender identity can lead to experiencing anxiety and stress when entering public spaces or engaging in social interactions, fearing negative reactions from others. To sum it up, dysphoria can be a serious condition that significantly lowers an individual's quality of life.

Trans people often seek medical interventions such as hormone therapy or gender-affirming surgeries, to alleviate dysphoria and bring their physical characteristics more in line with their gender identity. However, these are no simple interventions, many countries feature long waiting times and complicated procedures to get through to gain access to these, disregarding even the chance that these are considered taboo in an individual's cultural context. These also require an individual to have committed pretty heavily to a gender. Trans people often experience a long period of doubts, where they are not sure about their gender identity but still suffer from dysphoria. However, digital spaces can help both those who want to find a place free of dysphoria and those who want to experiment to a certain degree.

This is exactly the topic YouTuber Straszfilms covers in his video essay “Identity, Gender, and VRChat (Why is everyone in VR an anime girl?)”, where they investigated the reasons why so many users opt to play with a female avatar, even if the majority of the player base is of a different gender. It is easy to assume people choose female avatars because of aesthetic preferences or gameplay advantages, but Straszfilms took a deeper look. Within the context of that VR chat is mostly inhabited by female avatars, while it is mostly played by males (<70%), they found that over 55% of users think their identity accurately represents themselves. These users are in other words, exploring another self that has a different gender. They are performing as a different gender.

Furthermore, in Virtual Avatars: Trans Experiences of Ideal Selves Through Gaming, author Kai Baldwin hosts several interviews with transgender people about how their avatar in MMORPGs impacts dysphoria, with many of them stating the use of avatars and escaping to these digital spaces can help reduce their dysphoria, and that they can be reassured about themselves. Interestingly, there were also users that expressed how for them the use of avatars could be a way to break down the binary gender construct, expressing how they just want to be seen as themselves, instead of a certain gender (Baldwin 2019).

These examples show how trans users use digital spaces and the avatars and social contexts they provide as a way to escape incongruence. When individuals customize their avatars to match their idealized traits and appearances, they are aligning the avatar with their desired self-concept, thereby promoting a positive connection. While gender and sex are arguably a large part of your self-concept, your identity, I think you can extend this sentiment easily past sex and gender. Incongruence can appear in many ways, and these virtual social environments allow individuals to at least experience being congruent to a certain extent, and relieve symptoms of dysphoria. These kinds of environments are extremely rare in the real world, and that is exactly what makes them so valuable.

Exploring to grow and understand

Aside from seeking convergence and allowing an individual to feel more in line with themselves, I have not touched upon the value of being able to explore your identity so freely. I want to explain this through another prominent framework in developmental psychology, which is Erik Erikson's theory of identity formation. According to Erikson, individuals go through a series of psychosocial stages throughout their lives, and one of the key stages occurs during adolescence, where the primary challenge is establishing a sense of identity.

James Marcia expanded upon Erikson's theory by introducing the concept of identity statuses. Identity statuses are specific developmental stages that individuals pass through on their way to achieving a stable sense of identity, of which two are of interest for us. and The first interesting point where digital spaces can help out is when an individual finds themselves in identity foreclosure, where individuals have prematurely committed to an identity without thoroughly exploring other options. This commitment is often influenced by external factors such as parental or societal expectations, rather than personal exploration. These are again factors that, as already argued, are less of a factor in online spaces. A second phase many individuals find themselves in is identity moratorium, where individuals are actively exploring different aspects of their identity but have not yet made a final commitment. Here again as already argued, can the ease of which you can explore identity in online spaces make a difference. According to the theory, a stable, committed

sense of identity is built upon having explored yourself, and since online digital spaces can aid in this crucial phase, they can help individuals in their identity formation (Lumen 2023).

This also extends past exploring yourself, being able to explore your identity also promotes understanding of other individuals' situations. An example of this is a study done by Mel Slater and Maria V. Sanchez-Vives which investigates among other things if through the use of virtual reality avatars, it is possible to impact a user's racial biases. We already covered how VR avatars provide an illusion for your body and the close connection users experience with their virtual self. Starting from this, they had people experience avatars with a skin color different to theirs in virtual reality, and measured if this experience affected their racial biases. They concluded "the difference in body types, specifically skin color, was responsible for reducing implicit racial bias in the ED (embodied dark) group." (Slater 2014). They also did some other studies like how having child and adult avatars also provide a different experience. Having experiences like this, where an individual can look through the perspective of someone with a different gender or body features like skin color can really impact their own sense of identity.

Identity as self expression

I finally want to talk shortly about what we can, in my opinion, learn from how identity is treated in these online spaces. Self-expression is the act of sharing yourself with society. The discussion of why this is important to individuals is a discussion that requires another paper, so let us just assume it is, at least in Western countries where individualism is at its strongest. How you are perceived as an individual matters, and an important part of this is the impression you leave on people. With people you know through and through, you are more or less in control over this through your actions and dialogue, but others have to do with just the visible parts. Unfortunately, this is where control is limited. Constructs like race, sex, gender, social context, personal background unfortunately still matter to a lot of people, and while efforts are being made to break through these, they are hard to change. It is not necessarily a bad thing that an individual is associated with them, the bad thing is that they are not given a choice. I myself was born white, and whether I like it or not, this will always play a role in how people perceive me, even though I'd rather be perceived for what I like and stand for, or what social groups I choose to belong to and so on.

Throughout this paper, I mentioned many times that in online digital spaces individuals have the ability of being in control of how they self present through an avatar, and how you act. As an individual, you are given a blank template to color in yourself. This means that individuals here are as opposed to real life fully in control of how they are perceived. Even if some spaces may have their own social constructs and biases, users can change at will. They are given the choice of what they want to stand for, their identity is purely self-expression. Users know and understand that of each other, which creates a dynamic where the aforementioned impression left no longer is associated with pre-existing constructs without any choice, since everything is a choice. It is this central idea of identity being purely self-expression that I find beautiful. The impact this has on how users treat each other online, and whether we can learn from these spaces in the real world warrants it's own discussion, but it is on this open question, and the thought that maybe these digital virtual spaces are frontrunners of how we should approach identity in the future that I want to end this paper.

Conclusion

I hope that after this, I made it clear how I think these online digital spaces provide value in the context of identity formation. They provide a risk-free, easy to access playground of identity that can help individuals explore and accept latent parts of themselves. While VRChat and other virtual social platforms already manage to reach similar environments and social contexts to real life, this whole topic is in my opinion only going to get more relevant as digital spaces evolve next to technology. Having users be able to fully control their self presentation made it so that here identity pretty much is self-expression. Users can choose what to represent and what not. These online spaces may give us a small glimpse of what our future collective definition of identity may look like.

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